

The Spare Room

Writer development packet

22 September 2026 · Revision 3

A family play for three performers and one ordinary room. The next creative task is a complete first draft, once commission terms are agreed.

The outline and samples are working material. The opening and middle do not yet connect, the ending is not scripted, and the seventy-minute allocation has not been measured in a reading.

Reading order

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Character notes, voice notes, prior reviews and the development diary are optional supporting material in the editable source archive. Current revision 3 decisions take precedence over the historical versions.

1 Writer brief

We would like you to develop *The Spare Room* into a continuous stage play of approximately seventy minutes. The concept has had enough discussion to support drafting. This package gives you the present structure, exploratory dialogue and the decisions behind them. The next creative deliverable, once commission terms are agreed, should be a complete first draft.

The play

Helen wants her mother, Ruth, to move out of the home she has made for her inside herself. Kit, Helen's adult child, has come to help, partly because they want Helen's attention for a new beginning of their own.

The audience should recognise the family before understanding where they are. As its understanding expands, the impossible circumstances should change what the people can do to one another. The room and its objects remain materially simple while their meaning changes.

The emotional starting point is: can you love your mother and still want her out of your head? A further problem emerges when Helen discovers that an independent Ruth may no longer be the familiar mother she expects to visit.

What to protect

- Three performers, one stable playing space, ordinary furniture, objects and clothes. No additional voices or effects-dependent events.
- An emotionally accessible family argument, with pleasure and humour as well as hurt.
- Ruth as an autonomous, living person. Her move leads to another life.
- Consistent entrances and exits. The door marks participation in the encounter; an agreement changes residence.
- Helen's sincere original invitation. The present conflict renegotiates something that once helped both women.
- Freedom for the characters to be partial, petty, mistaken and surprising.

The two practical clarifications

Sharing a view is different from living here. Kit's invitation permits a temporary sharing of Helen's present sensory attention. Closing it removes that view. Kit can still speak normally in the room. Ruth's residence lets her address Helen even after Helen leaves the encounter; Helen can refuse to answer but cannot stop receiving the call while leaving that residence intact. In the revised passage, Kit loses the harbour, Helen steps out, and Ruth can still reach her.

All printed dialogue is public. Receiving the private fragment is silent and acted. The chair and the conversation about Helen's invitation prompt her recollection. Kit receives one remembered instant, then chooses to use it. It is Helen's experience of a moment, not objective evidence settling what the promise meant.

The quiet trial changes Ruth's choice. For a sustained interval, Ruth keeps quiet and Helen enjoys her wider life. It works as proposed. Ruth discovers she would be staying partly to wait for a familiar daughter to return. She chooses Sal's invitation to learn a dance instead. Helen initially accepts the departure, then tries to secure visits in the familiar room and form. Ruth stays to challenge the assumption that leaving would mean accepting those conditions. Kit's gathering creates Kit's urgency; it is not a deadline that forces Ruth out.

Freedom in the draft

The nine movements and their timings are a working route, not a prescribed scene count. The names, private chronology, professions, individual jokes and final image can change where the writing gives a stronger reason. The dialogue is exploratory material to develop or replace, not a voice the writer must imitate line by line.

The early swimming-bag passage is retained from revision 1 and needs integration. The revised middle is continuous, but it does not join directly to that opening: movement two and other linking material remain to be written. The final four movements are outlined, not scripted. No runtime has been established.

The ending is especially open. The current proposal has Ruth leave independently, then Helen choose to accompany Kit in a familiar form. Write it and judge its effect in the complete play. There is no obligation to preserve “just for the arrival,” the empty room, or that particular final action if they make the result too neat.

Three questions to test through scenes

1. **Does Kit's disclosure stay proportionate?** It should alter trust without making the rest of the play solely about the breach. Kit uses a fragment to advance a case they already wanted to make. Helen's subsequent care need not restore the intimacy she withdrew.
2. **Do these people exceed their descriptions?** Their work, pleasures, bad stories and embarrassments should make them particular and enjoyable. Some details can matter to them without illustrating the play's argument.
3. **Does the ending earn its uncertainty?** Give Ruth's departure its own weight. Let Helen want company, retain mistrust, and be able to refuse Kit. Hear whether the final request invites thought or merely announces a repeated family pattern.

These are questions for the draft and an eventual reading, not requests for another treatment answering every objection.

Reading the package

Start with the reading packet: this brief, the nine-movement outline, the retained opening and revised middle pages. The ZIP also contains editable sources and optional character and voice notes. Earlier versions, reviews and the development diary sit in the source folders as history; they do not override revision 3.

The original brief and earlier feedback are there if useful. You do not need to read the entire conversation before drafting.

Commission arrangements

This is intended as a paid professional commission. Fee, schedule, payment stages, revision scope, credit and rights remain to be agreed in writing before commissioned work begins. Please confirm your availability and proposed working terms. No additional unpaid scenes or original treatment are requested for selection.

After a complete draft, the next useful test is a three-voice reading: actual duration, clarity of the room's actions, changing sympathy, and what listeners think remains unresolved after the disclosure and departure.

2 Scene outline

Revision 3 for writer handoff: a limited rules-and-causality pass following the producer follow-up.

Revision 2 is preserved. The later concerns about proportion, individuality and the ending remain tests for the full draft.

Nine continuous movements, provisionally seventy minutes. These allocations describe the intended shape; they are not measured performance times. The new dramatic pages test part of the middle. A full draft and a timed reading remain necessary.

The engine

Helen has brought a bag to help her mother, Ruth, move out. Kit, Helen's adult child, has encouraged both women to believe the arrangements are further advanced than they are.

This evening Kit begins life in a household with Neri and seven other people. Helen said she would *try* to attend their first shared meal. Kit has told Neri she is coming. Kit wants their mother beside them for something frightening and pleasurable; they also want, for once, her attention without Ruth in it.

The gathering can proceed without Kit or Helen. There is no disaster if they miss it. But these people will begin their life together, and Kit will have to join a beginning already shared by the others. Kit's false assurance makes the cost worse. This is Kit's urgency, not a deadline forcing Ruth to move. Helen has chosen today to ask directly; Ruth chooses today only after the trial makes staying mean something different to her.

Ruth can live elsewhere. The difficult question is whether Helen will accept her leaving without preserving the version of her mother she expects to visit.

What the staging must make readable

The same three actors, ordinary furniture and single entrance serve throughout. No voice or performer represents Neri or Sal.

- The entrance marks entering or leaving this encounter. Crossing it does not itself change residency.
- While Ruth lives within Helen, she can address Helen when Helen is elsewhere. Helen can refuse to answer, but cannot stop receiving that call while leaving the residence intact. Kit has no such residence.
- Helen presents a familiar bodily and conversational self here. She can relax that accommodation without becoming a different character.
- Helen can invite Kit to share her current sensory attention. She means to show the harbour and trusts Kit to treat the intimacy discreetly; the invitation is not a perfectly isolated picture of the harbour. A fragment of memory can intrude when Helen relives it. Kit cannot search or direct her memories, and receives her experience rather than an objective record.
- Helen can end that shared view. Kit remains able to speak normally in the room. Nothing about closing the view removes Ruth's residence or her ability to call Helen.
- Agreement and departure end Ruth's residence. She remains alive and independent; the room remains Helen's.

The invitation into Helen's wider experience must be demonstrated as pleasurable before it enables an injury. Ruth's need for the familiar Helen must be demonstrated before Helen demands a familiar Ruth.

All spoken dialogue is public. Private receipt is silent and acted; a subsequent utterance makes the received detail public. The chair and Ruth's account of the invitation trigger Helen's recollection. After the breach, repeat the earlier exit pattern: Kit loses the view, Helen steps out, Kit cannot call her back, Ruth can. This supplies the distinction without a technology lesson.

Private continuity choices, including the elapsed years and each person's life elsewhere, are in Characters and the Conceptual Map. They need not all become lines.

1. The bag 0 to 7 minutes

Wants: Helen wants packing to confirm a completed decision. Ruth wants Helen to ask, rather than implement. Kit wants the two agreements they have overstated to become true before either is checked.

Action: Retain the swimming-bag opening from the first dialogue draft, revising Kit's evasions around their concealed commitment. Cold tea, a scarf and the chair provide delays, but the scene must reach a direct question: did Ruth agree to move today?

Helen calls Kit as her witness. Kit admits Ruth said today was better than Thursday, not that she would go. Under pressure, Kit acknowledges having told Helen Ruth was ready.

Turn: Helen learns Kit helped create the apparent agreement. Ruth makes Helen stop packing.

Audience gains: A mother, daughter and grandchild are negotiating a move. Kit is implicated from the start, rather than positioned outside the conflict.

What can no longer proceed: Helen cannot complete the move by treating Ruth's consent as an administrative fact.

Rhythm: Quick familiarity with enough pleasure to make this family worth staying with. Seven minutes is a ceiling to test, not a quota for empty-bag business.

2. The other promise 7 to 15 minutes

Wants: Helen wants a reason Ruth cannot dispute. Ruth wants to prove that staying could be easy. Kit wants Helen at their gathering and does not yet want to reveal what they told Neri.

Action: Kit steps out to check their arrangements. Ruth calls after them without effect. Helen tries to leave for her own brief private conversation; Ruth continues speaking and Helen answers from outside, returning exasperated.

Helen argues from the inconvenience of maintaining the room. Ruth knows it is slight. Helen admits she wants intervals when nobody can call her back. Kit presses their own invitation, bringing tonight's first meal into the argument. Helen remembers promising to try.

Ruth proposes a trial: she will keep quiet, and Helen can do what she likes while remaining here. Kit backs it because a successful trial might let Helen attend without completing the move.

Turn: Helen agrees to try. They have chosen an apparently workable alternative, not merely described one they tried long ago.

Audience gains: Helen's availability is literal and unequal. Kit has a positive reason to hurry. The place Ruth might move to is Sal's house, which Ruth already knows.

What can no longer proceed: The move cannot be justified as a physical necessity. They must try the less painful solution they have proposed.

Rhythm: The bustle stops. The three must endure the experiment they have agreed to.

3. Being here differently 15 to 25 minutes

Wants: Helen wants to remain present without narrowing herself to the daughter Ruth recognises. Kit wants to join the Helen they enjoy elsewhere. Ruth wants the quiet trial to work, but discovers she wants a particular kind of answer too.

Action: Helen lets the familiar stance and sequence of attention loosen. Kit recognises the change, asks to share what she is experiencing, and receives permission. They enjoy a harbour tide Helen has made; Kit

answers an observation before Helen has spoken it. Helen has room for a longer, awkwardly happy attempt to describe her work.

Ruth tries to participate. For a moment they laugh together over an old dance Ruth called wrongly; the amusement need not injure anyone. Ruth then explicitly lets Helen finish the work. A sustained interval follows in which Ruth really does keep quiet and Helen enjoys the harbour with Kit. Helen turns back voluntarily when it is done.

The compromise has worked in its narrow terms. Ruth discovers that staying can mean waiting quietly for the familiar daughter, with no guarantee that answering will bring that daughter back. She can secure familiar Helen by asking, but does not want to spend her days waiting and making that request.

Helen tries to include Ruth in the larger experience. Ruth can attempt this kind of contact, but recoils from learning how with an unfamiliar version of her daughter. She wants Helen to come back properly.

Helen finally says, impatiently, that Ruth lives in her and that this is how she is when she is not arranging herself for the room. It confirms the action; it does not launch an explanation.

Turn: Helen resumes the familiar form, at a cost the actor makes perceptible. Ruth remembers that Sal offered to show her a dance before the others arrive. She chooses to go and learn it, rather than remain waiting here. She begins packing. This is a positive alternative she already knows, not a new destination supplied by the plot.

Audience gains: The room is a meeting place within Helen. Keeping Ruth's company involves making a particular self available. Helen's wider life contains pleasure as well as obligations.

What can no longer proceed: Ruth will not keep the residence on the basis of this successful quiet. Its cost to her has become concrete. The scene need not prove that every possible compromise would fail.

Rhythm: An experiment, genuine pleasure, a wandering story, then discomfort. Avoid twenty-five minutes of escalating short retorts.

4. The chair stops the move 25 to 34 minutes

Wants: Ruth wants to leave for the life she has privately begun imagining. Helen wants to complete the move while securing recognisable future visits. Kit wants to seize Ruth's agreement and go.

Action: Ruth packs decisively. She has liked Sal's house for weeks, and has been asked to call a dance there. She admits the new dancers do not keep separate movements or always use the bodies Helen expects. She intends to learn.

Helen offers to retain the room exactly as it is for visits. Ruth moves the chair out of its customary position. She hated the original chair, which she had replaced; this preserved version comes from Helen's memory. She refuses to return to the same place and same shape simply to reassure Helen.

Kit takes the packed bag to accompany her. Helen takes it back. She wants a definite promise that Ruth will return to this room in the familiar form. Ruth could leave without the bag, but Helen is speaking as though accepting the move would also accept those visiting terms. Ruth stays to make Helen acknowledge that no such agreement exists. Her purpose is control over future visits, not recovery of a transport device.

Turn: Helen stops the departure she spent the opening trying to arrange. Ruth tells her to put the chair back herself if she wants it there.

Audience gains: Helen has maintained selected parts of their shared past. Ruth's proposed home offers change, not just less demanding care.

What can no longer proceed: Ruth will not accept a move whose unspoken condition is remaining Helen's familiar mother on request. Helen will not yet give her the bag on other terms.

Rhythm: Packing briefly becomes fast and competent. Helen's obstruction must be conspicuous, not a sentiment inferred from another argument.

5. An invitation misused 34 to 43 minutes

Wants: Ruth wants her original sacrifice acknowledged. Helen wants the present dispute kept separate from a night of desperate need. Kit wants to use the intimacy Helen granted them to force the decision forward.

Action: Kit asks the retained question: “Are you going to expect me to do this for you?” Helen says no; Ruth says she did not expect it either.

The women quarrel about the invitation. Helen had left a long shared marriage and could not bear the first nights alone. Ruth gave up a place with travelling dance callers. The potatoes exchange remains: Helen asked questions to keep Ruth talking; Ruth now knows that.

Helen and Kit's invited contact has not yet been withdrawn. Looking at the chair while Ruth recalls the invitation prompts a fragment of Helen's memory: being on the floor, asking Ruth to breathe louder. Kit receives it silently, then looks towards the bag and chooses to use it aloud. They claim the moment proves Ruth should leave. Helen rejects that inference: Kit does not know what she asked afterwards. A received memory is neither complete testimony nor an explanation of the promise.

Helen ends the shared view: the water is gone for Kit. She briefly steps out. Kit cannot reach her; Ruth calls and Helen answers from outside, then returns. Closing the view has not ended Ruth's residence. Kit cannot recover the invitation by insisting they meant to help. Only now do they admit that Neri expects Helen's definite attendance.

Turn: Helen refuses to accompany Kit under a promise Kit made for her. Kit must go outside and correct their assurance to Neri.

Audience gains: The original promise was “As long as you like.” Invited closeness can make a private memory available without making its use permissible. Kit can inflict harm, and has recruited Helen as ruthlessly as either older woman recruited them.

What can no longer proceed: Kit cannot remain Helen's privileged companion inside the argument or quietly deliver her to the household as promised.

Rhythm: The memory has time to hurt before Kit tries to make it useful. The breach should be a specific act, not a general discussion of mental privacy.

6. Without the witness 43 to 51 minutes

Wants: Ruth wants Helen to acknowledge what she surrendered. Helen wants to stop owing her entire future to it. Both also want relief from being watched by Kit.

Action: Kit leaves to speak to Neri. Alone, the women stop performing their best accounts for the grandchild.

Helen challenges Ruth's travelling-group story. Ruth did give up a place, but she was already uneasy about no longer leading everything herself. Ruth challenges Helen's account of the marriage: Helen left; she was not simply deserted. Neither correction cancels the actual loneliness or care.

Let an unfinished story or a wholly ordinary reminiscence run here without requiring a lesson. Ruth can fail to finish it. Helen can fail to find a useful reply. No object must rescue the silence.

Ruth gets her bag back from Helen and sets it by the entrance. Helen does not retrieve it.

Turn: Helen allows a concrete preparatory act of departure before receiving reassurance about future visits.

Audience gains: Both women have selected the past to make their present positions defensible. Their affection also survives occasions when neither can turn it into evidence.

What can no longer proceed: Helen cannot restore the old arrangement by attributing Ruth's whole life to her sacrifice. Ruth cannot require gratitude to settle every future decision.

Rhythm: A slower duet. Its necessary endpoint is the returned bag; its internal route remains open to drafting.

7. A visit rehearsed badly 51 to 59 minutes

Wants: Helen wants proof that they will still know how to meet. Ruth wants freedom for herself while still recognising Helen. Kit, returning partway through, wants somewhere to stand after their new household has started without them.

Action: Helen asks Ruth to try meeting her differently now. This reprises the earlier trial with the stakes reversed: Ruth is preparing for change herself.

Helen loosens the familiar presentation again. Ruth can answer her, but struggles to address her as her daughter. She asks Helen to come back. Helen points out the asymmetry badly, with anger rather than an elegant account of reciprocity. Ruth still will not promise that she herself will return unchanged.

Kit returns. They have told Neri what happened; the others have begun. Neri has not expelled or punished Kit. Kit has missed the experience they wanted Helen to share and has had to admit lying about her agreement.

Turn: No rehearsal supplies a mutually reassuring version of the future. Ruth nevertheless puts on her coat.

Audience gains: Ruth's wish to change does not instantly make her generous about Helen's changes. Kit's deadline had a real, proportionate cost.

What can no longer proceed: The move cannot wait for both women to feel ready, or for a demonstration that future meetings will be comfortable.

Rhythm: A short, exposed attempt at contact. Resist repeating all the positions from movement three; this attempt ends sooner because Ruth now has a bag beside the door.

8. Ruth goes 59 to 66 minutes

Wants: Ruth wants to arrive at Sal's with the ability to decide what happens next. Helen wants to help and to make one last bid for certainty. Kit wants to repair something and offers to accompany Ruth.

Action: Ruth declines the escort. She knows where she is going. Her independence must include the ordinary possibility of misjudging Sal or being a poor beginner, without the play threatening annihilation.

Helen and Ruth make the change of residence explicit in a brief practical exchange. Ruth will no longer be able to call through the room and receive Helen wherever she is. Visits are possible; neither promises a schedule or a recognisable form.

A sleeve catches. Ruth permits help, or asks Kit instead of Helen: choose in the full draft according to what the actors have made of their allegiance. This is a small remaining choice, not the scene's main action.

Ruth leaves for Sal's. Helen does not follow. Ruth does not return for spectacles.

Turn: The move occurs without either woman obtaining the assurance she wanted.

Audience gains: Departure means another life. The familiar mother may change beyond the present terms of recognition; she is not deleted, revealed as unreal, or secretly dying.

What can no longer proceed: They cannot continue negotiating as if no decision has been enacted. Future contact will begin from elsewhere.

Rhythm: Give the departure enough ordinary duration to be real. Do not underline it with a scenic transformation.

9. Just for the arrival 66 to 70 minutes

Wants: Kit still wants Helen beside them when they enter their household late. Helen wants contact after the rupture and also has a wider self to return to.

Action: Kit asks again, this time acknowledging that Helen did not promise attendance. Helen agrees to accompany them.

As Helen begins to meet Kit in the expansive manner Kit earlier preferred, Kit falters. They ask for the familiar mother “just for the arrival,” wanting her hand while they face Neri after admitting the lie. Earlier Kit advertised Helen's impressive work; now they want to arrive as someone's child before taking their place among equals. Let the request, not an explanatory speech, reveal this. Kit celebrated the expansive Helen while Ruth found her difficult; their own shame now makes familiar reassurance desirable.

Helen considers. She deliberately resumes that familiar form and leaves with Kit. Her choice is neither compelled by the room nor presented as proof that no separation is possible.

The room remains, empty. No object supplies a final moral.

Turn: Helen has obtained the freedom she asked for and uses some of it to accommodate her child. How much she has freely given, and how much she has already resumed carrying, is unsettled.

Audience gains: No further mechanism. The final action spends what the audience already knows.

What has changed: Ruth has moved. Kit's first evening began without them. Helen's relationship to both is altered, but recognisable need remains.

Rhythm: Brief, awkward, with no summing-up speech.

Test in the full draft: Let Ruth's departure register before Kit asks. Helen may want company herself; Kit must be able to hear a refusal. Accompanying Kit need not restore the shared perception Helen withdrew. Care can continue while trust has not recovered. Test whether “just for the arrival” overstates the echo of the old promise; the wording and ending remain replaceable.

Revelation order

By approximately	What the audience understands	What changes the action
7 minutes	Kit overstated Ruth's consent	Packing stops
15 minutes	Helen remains reachable; tonight matters to Kit	They choose a quiet trial
25 minutes	Helen contains the room; quiet does not guarantee familiar company	Ruth chooses Sal's life over waiting here
34 minutes	Helen preserves the room; Ruth may change beyond it	Helen stops the move
43 minutes	Helen begged Ruth to stay; shared intimacy can expose memory	Kit misuses it and loses access
51 minutes	The family accounts omit inconvenient choices	Helen gives back the bag
59 minutes	A future meeting may hurt despite goodwill	Ruth puts on her coat without resolving that hurt
66 minutes	Residence has ended; Ruth lives elsewhere	Helen and Kit must speak without her
70 minutes	The familiar mother is something Helen can choose to provide	Helen leaves with Kit; the room remains

What remains open

The causal spine is a draft proposition, not a claim that every movement works. In particular:

- The audience must be able to distinguish shared experience from simultaneous conversation. If Kit's acquisition of the private memory reads as a guess, the central new action has failed.
- The chair scene must actually prevent a departure that could have happened. More information about furniture is insufficient.
- Movements six and seven may need compressing or combining after a continuous read. Time should go to lived encounters, not an extra round of an already clear argument.
- The ending is a new working version. Keep it only if Helen's choice feels both voluntary and costly, rather than illustrating an inevitable cycle.
- Kit's disclosure must not make resolving the violation the sole remaining subject. Ask listeners what they now think the play needs to resolve.
- Particulars and longer speeches must make these people enjoyable and surprising, rather than merely illustrating the development notes.
- The dancing story, the exact interruption and the sleeve business can change. The biographies should supply choices, not compel explanatory speeches.

A cold reader should be able to recount the same physical events as another reader while disagreeing about which person has been most generous or most unfair.

3 Retained opening

From revision 1. Retained material for the opening movement, not an integrated first act. Kit's evasions need aligning with the revised outline. The superseded later sample is not included here.

From the first movement. The audience does not yet need to understand anything speculative.

RUTH sits at the table. HELEN stands behind her, holding her coat open. KIT has put a bag on an empty chair.

RUTH: Is that for my things?

KIT: Yes.

RUTH: That's your swimming bag.

KIT: It's dry.

RUTH: I didn't ask whether it was wet.

HELEN: There's hardly anything to take.

RUTH: Good. It won't take long when I've decided.

HELEN: You have decided.

RUTH holds out a hand. HELEN moves the coat towards it.

RUTH: My glasses.

HELEN gives her the glasses from the table.

KIT: I can get another bag.

HELEN: The bag is fine.

RUTH: I'm sure it is.

KIT: That sounded --

HELEN: It's fine.

KIT opens the bag.

KIT: What first?

HELEN: The blue mug.

RUTH: No.

HELEN: You said you wanted your own things around you.

RUTH: Some of them.

HELEN: You use it every day.

RUTH: It's the one that's here.

KIT picks up the mug.

RUTH: There's tea in that.

KIT puts it down.

KIT: Right.

HELEN: I'll drink it.

RUTH: It's cold.

HELEN: I don't mind.

HELEN has to put the coat down to pick up the mug. RUTH takes the coat and folds it across her knees.

KIT: I could start with clothes.

RUTH: You could sit down.

KIT: I've only got --

HELEN: We know.

RUTH: I don't.

KIT: I said I'd be back in an hour.

RUTH: Then you'd better not sit down.

HELEN drinks.

RUTH: I told you.

HELEN: It's all right.

RUTH: Your face says otherwise.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: What?

HELEN puts the mug down.

HELEN: We said we would do this today.

RUTH: You said today.

HELEN: And you said that would be --

RUTH: I said today was better than Thursday.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I have something on Thursday.

HELEN: You could have told me that was what you meant.

RUTH: It was in the same sentence.

KIT: What's on Thursday?

HELEN: It doesn't matter what's on Thursday.

RUTH: It does to me.

A pause.

HELEN: Kit. You were here.

KIT: For which bit?

HELEN: When we discussed it.

KIT: I came in at the end.

HELEN: You heard her say today would be better.

KIT: I heard Thursday.

HELEN: You must have heard more than the word Thursday.

KIT: I was looking for my bag.

They all look at the bag.

RUTH: There it is.

KIT almost laughs. HELEN sees.

KIT: Sorry.

HELEN: I asked you to come and help.

KIT: I am trying to help. What goes in the bag?

RUTH starts unfolding the coat.

HELEN moves to assist her. RUTH folds it again, more neatly.

RUTH: Don't put clothes in with the mug.

KIT: I haven't put anything in.

RUTH: I can see that.

KIT lifts the bag off the chair and puts it on the floor. To sit down, they move the chair away from the table.

HELEN: Leave that where it was.

RUTH: It's in the way there.

HELEN: It's always been there.

RUTH: Yes.

KIT remains standing, holding the chair.

KIT: Here?

RUTH: That's fine.

HELEN: There isn't room.

KIT sits.

KIT: There is.

HELEN looks at the empty bag. She picks it up and holds it open herself.

HELEN: Your scarf, then. Can we put your scarf in?

RUTH considers this.

RUTH: The light one.

HELEN finds it beneath the coat. She places it in the bag.

RUTH: If we go.

4 Continuous middle passage

Revision 3 for writer handoff. A limited pass clarifies the quiet trial, Ruth's choice to leave, and the distinction between shared perception and residence. This continuous exploratory passage covers movements three to five of the outline; it is not a complete act and has not been timed in a reading.

The first dialogue draft preserves the earlier opening and later sample. The swimming-bag opening remains the intended starting material. Here the audience has already seen Ruth reach Helen outside the room and fail to reach Kit. Kit has disclosed the household gathering this evening, but not the assurance given to Neri.

Three actors throughout. Ordinary clothes. Table, three chairs, flask, mugs, spectacles, coat, scarf and a swimming bag. One entrance. No changes of light or sound announce changes of attention.

All printed dialogue is spoken aloud and can be heard by everyone present. Shared perception is received silently, through attention and response. No unmarked aside or private spoken voice is used. Kit can see with Helen temporarily; Ruth's residence lets her call Helen even when Helen has left this encounter. Closing the former does not end the latter.

HELEN has agreed to try doing what she wants while remaining with RUTH. RUTH has promised not to interrupt. KIT has stopped packing.

HELEN sits. She waits.

RUTH: Go on.

HELEN: I am.

RUTH: All right.

A little time.

KIT: You don't have to watch her.

RUTH: Where would you like me to look?

KIT: Anywhere.

RUTH: That's where I'm looking.

HELEN laughs once, unwillingly. She settles further into the chair, turned a little towards KIT. Her feet and hands cease their small readiness to attend to RUTH. Nothing makes her vacant or solemn. She is interested in something.

RUTH: Is that it?

HELEN: Nearly.

RUTH: Tell me when.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: Then I can start being quiet.

KIT turns towards HELEN.

KIT: Is it the harbour?

HELEN nods.

KIT: Can I?

HELEN: Yes. Wait. Let it come to you.

KIT sits. Their shoulders rise. They laugh, surprised.

KIT: Oh, that's cold.

HELEN: You asked.

KIT: Where am I standing?

HELEN: Don't stand anywhere.

KIT: I have to stand somewhere.

HELEN: That's why you keep falling in.

KIT adjusts, concentrating.

RUTH: Are your feet wet?

KIT: No.

RUTH: Well.

HELEN: You can have a look.

RUTH: I'm quite comfortable.

HELEN: You don't have to get up.

RUTH: I know that, Helen.

HELEN lets the offer go.

KIT: Someone's left a --

HELEN: I know.

KIT: They'll lose it.

HELEN: It's tied on.

RUTH: What is?

HELEN: A small boat.

RUTH: What kind?

HELEN: Red.

RUTH: That's not a kind of boat.

KIT: Very small. With something in it.

HELEN almost speaks.

KIT: A shoe.

HELEN looks at KIT.

KIT: Sorry. You were just looking at it.

HELEN: You can look. You don't have to say everything.

KIT: It was a very sudden shoe.

RUTH: Shoes do turn up in boats.

HELEN: Do they?

RUTH: If someone goes out wearing two and comes back wearing one, that's where I'd look.

KIT bends with laughter. HELEN joins them.

RUTH: What?

KIT: Nothing.

RUTH: I haven't said anything funny.

HELEN: You sounded so pleased with yourself.

RUTH: Well, I've solved it.

They are still amused. RUTH allows herself to be too.

KIT: Did you put the shoe there?

HELEN: No. I don't do the shoes.

RUTH: What do you do?

HELEN: The water.

RUTH: All of it?

HELEN: Enough of it.

KIT: She did the steps.

HELEN: I didn't do the steps. I made the water reach them together.

RUTH: Is that difficult?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I only asked.

HELEN: No, I'm telling you. It's very difficult. The harbour narrows here, and then there's a bit nobody admits is a harbour because the houses are horrible. It is still a harbour. Water doesn't look at the houses and make a decision. So if you want the same wave to reach both sets of steps, you have to let it come round the long way without making the people in the middle think you've forgotten them. I had it once. Yesterday. They were all standing there with their feet just above it, waiting. And then a child jumped in early. Which was fair enough. It was water.

KIT: I would have.

HELEN: You'd have complained about the temperature first.

RUTH: Were the parents there?

HELEN: Probably. Mum, that's not -- I liked it. They'd all been waiting for something very beautiful and this child made a horrible noise and everyone got splashed. I liked that better. I tried to tell the others and they thought I meant we should arrange it that way. Put the child in. Put the noise in. Which is completely --

She cannot find the word. She makes a frustrated gesture. KIT has received something of it and begins to laugh.

HELEN: No. Don't say it.

KIT: I wasn't going to.

HELEN: You were.

KIT: You're still showing me.

HELEN: Then stop enjoying it so much.

She looks towards RUTH, still smiling.

HELEN: You'd have liked it.

RUTH: It sounds messy.

HELEN: It was.

RUTH: Were you in it?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: On the steps?

HELEN: There as well.

RUTH: Well, I wouldn't have known where to wave.

HELEN: You could have waved anywhere.

RUTH: I don't wave at water. People take you home.

HELEN laughs. KIT does too, then stops as a second thought comes.

KIT: Did they say it was yours?

HELEN: What?

KIT: The tide.

HELEN: It doesn't matter.

KIT: Did they?

HELEN: They said we'd done a good job.

KIT: Ah.

RUTH: You always did want your name on things.

HELEN: It's nice when you've made them.

RUTH: You wrote it on the sofa.

HELEN: I didn't make the sofa.

RUTH: No. That was my point.

HELEN turns partly towards KIT again, her attention easy between them and the water. RUTH watches her.

RUTH: Will you be back for tea?

HELEN: I'm here.

RUTH: Later.

HELEN: I don't know what you mean.

RUTH: Neither do I, apparently.

A pause.

KIT: Neri said you could do something like that tonight.

HELEN: I said I'd try to come.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: You haven't asked me to do a tide.

KIT: No. Something little.

HELEN: I said I'd try to come.

KIT: It doesn't have to be anything.

RUTH: She has work to do.

KIT: She was just saying she likes it.

RUTH: I like dancing. I don't dance every time someone opens a door.

HELEN: You used to.

RUTH: That was my job.

KIT: Didn't you once --

RUTH: No, because everyone tells that wrong.

KIT: I haven't told it yet.

RUTH: Your mother will. It was a Friday. I know it was Friday because we couldn't have the hall on Saturdays. The man with the pigeons had it.

HELEN: He raced them.

RUTH: Not in the hall.

KIT: That would be a very short race.

RUTH: They had meetings. Anyway. I called left when I should have called right. In the first dance. Everyone went left. Perfectly reasonable. But I went on calling the next bit as though they'd gone right, and by then they were all halfway across the hall and the pianist couldn't see me.

HELEN: There wasn't a pianist.

RUTH: There was somebody making a noise.

KIT: The pigeons.

RUTH laughs before she can stop herself.

RUTH: Will you let me finish?

HELEN: Go on.

RUTH: Now I don't know where I was.

KIT: Nobody does. They're all going left.

They laugh. RUTH shakes her head at KIT, then begins laughing again.

RUTH: It was quite a good dance, as it turned out. A woman came up afterwards. "So refreshing." She had a hat on. I remember thinking she'd kept that on all evening and nobody had knocked it off. We must have done something right.

HELEN: Did you tell her?

RUTH: I said thank you.

The laughter subsides without turning against anyone.

RUTH: Go on. Finish it.

HELEN: I can stop.

RUTH: I said I'd wait.

HELEN turns towards KIT. Their attention follows something together. KIT nearly speaks; HELEN's smile stops them. They watch it finish.

RUTH waits. She does not call, prompt or ask them to return. Leave enough time for the shared pleasure to continue without her.

HELEN: There. That worked.

HELEN looks towards RUTH. Her feet stay where they are; her attention does not gather into its earlier pattern.

RUTH: I didn't call you.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: Are you coming back now?

HELEN: I'm here.

RUTH: Properly.

RUTH cannot complete what she was going to say.

KIT: She doesn't have to stop everything.

RUTH: I didn't ask her to.

KIT: You did just --

HELEN: Kit.

HELEN gives RUTH her hand, palm upwards. RUTH begins to take it in an ordinary clasp.

HELEN: You can come and look. You don't have to stay.

RUTH lets go before taking her hand fully.

RUTH: I said I'd keep quiet.

HELEN: You don't have to keep quiet.

RUTH: Then why are we doing this?

HELEN: Because you live in me, Mum. When I go somewhere, you can still call me. If you're staying, I need to be able to be like this here sometimes.

RUTH: You can.

HELEN: All right.

A pause.

RUTH: Could you come back for a minute first?

HELEN looks at her. Then she turns her chair square to RUTH, sets both feet down, and waits. The familiar readiness returns. No lighting change.

HELEN: What is it?

RUTH: Nothing. I was --

Silence.

RUTH: Sal said she'd show me before the others arrived.

HELEN: The dance?

RUTH: I've kept saying Thursday.

RUTH takes the scarf from the coat.

RUTH: I'll go now.

HELEN: You don't have to say that now.

RUTH: If I arrive after they've started, I'll just stand there nodding as though I know it.

KIT: The bag's here.

KIT rises immediately.

RUTH: I can see the bag.

KIT: Sorry.

RUTH folds the scarf once and puts it in the bag. She is much quicker at this than either visitor. She retrieves her spectacles.

HELEN: Put those somewhere you can find them.

RUTH: I have a place.

She puts them in her coat pocket.

HELEN: You'll forget they're there.

RUTH: You can tell me I told you so on Thursday.

KIT: So Thursday is Sal's?

RUTH: Thursday has been Sal's for a while.

HELEN: You didn't like it.

RUTH: I didn't like the person who showed us round.

HELEN: That was Sal.

RUTH: She's better when she isn't showing you round.

HELEN: I sent you two other places.

RUTH: I know.

HELEN: You could have told me.

RUTH: You'd already sent them.

HELEN picks up the mug.

HELEN: This?

RUTH: No. Sal's got cups.

KIT: You said she didn't.

RUTH: She's bought some.

KIT: For you?

RUTH: Not everything's for me.

RUTH takes the mug from HELEN, wipes its base with her thumb, and puts it on the table.

HELEN: They drink tea now?

RUTH: Some of them. They made quite a fuss about the cake.

KIT: Did they eat it?

RUTH: They admired it.

HELEN: You brought a whole cake?

RUTH: Well, I wasn't taking them one with a bit out.

KIT shoulders the bag. HELEN notices KIT turn, briefly, towards something neither woman has addressed.

HELEN: Still got the water?

KIT: Just a bit.

HELEN: Leave that bit alone.

KIT: I'm not doing anything to it.

HELEN: You were about to.

KIT grins. HELEN nearly does.

KIT: Are you going to teach them?

RUTH: Sal asked if I'd call.

HELEN: You said you couldn't follow it.

RUTH: They're showing me.

HELEN: You said you couldn't tell whose feet were whose.

RUTH: I couldn't.

HELEN: That doesn't sound --

RUTH: You didn't mind being all that water.

HELEN puts the coat over her arm.

HELEN: You can come back here afterwards. Tell me how it went.

RUTH: Not tonight.

HELEN: Tomorrow, then.

RUTH: I don't know.

HELEN: I'm trying to arrange a visit.

RUTH: We've barely managed to arrange leaving.

KIT: We could have done both by now.

HELEN: Kit, please.

HELEN puts the coat on the chair RUTH habitually uses.

HELEN: It'll all be here. You won't have to worry about that. You can come and sit --

RUTH lifts the coat and moves the chair away from its place.

HELEN: What are you doing?

RUTH: Getting my coat.

HELEN: You don't need to move that.

RUTH: It's in the way.

HELEN: It was fine.

RUTH: Put it wherever you like when I've gone.

HELEN puts it back.

KIT: Mum.

HELEN: What?

KIT: Nothing.

RUTH: That's not where it was.

HELEN: That's exactly where it was.

RUTH: Not at home. I got rid of that chair.

HELEN: No, you didn't.

RUTH: I think I'd remember.

HELEN: You sat in it every evening.

RUTH: For a while. It hurt the back of my leg. I gave it to the woman downstairs.

HELEN: You told me she borrowed it.

RUTH: She was borrowing everything. I wanted her to keep something.

RUTH moves the chair again, further from the table.

HELEN: I remember you in it.

RUTH: Well, here I am.

HELEN: I wasn't --

RUTH: Put it back yourself if you want it there.

HELEN does not move it.

KIT: I've got everything. Shall we?

HELEN: Wait.

KIT: What?

HELEN: Just wait.

HELEN takes the bag from KIT.

KIT: I'll carry it.

HELEN: We haven't --

She sets it behind her chair.

RUTH: Give that back.

HELEN: I'm trying to understand what you've agreed to.

RUTH: I'm going to Sal's.

HELEN: And after that?

RUTH: I'll take my coat off.

HELEN: You know what I mean.

RUTH: Actually I don't.

HELEN: You said they don't always have --

She gestures at RUTH.

RUTH: These? No. Not always.

HELEN: And you won't?

RUTH: I might like it.

HELEN: But when you come here.

RUTH: When I come here what?

HELEN: Here. Like this. We can agree that much.

RUTH: We haven't.

RUTH: You held your hand out to me just now.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I saw it. I couldn't do it. That doesn't mean I won't ever do anything.

HELEN: I didn't say that.

RUTH: Then give me my bag.

HELEN: I don't want the next time I see you to be something you haven't told me about.

RUTH: I don't know what to tell you about yet.

HELEN: You could wait until you do.

RUTH: And if I walk out now, you'll tell Kit we arranged Thursday here.

HELEN: We could.

RUTH: I'm waiting for you to say we haven't.

KIT looks from the bag to HELEN.

KIT: We came to take her.

HELEN: I know why we came.

KIT: She's ready.

HELEN: She's upset.

RUTH: Then don't upset me any more. Give me the bag.

RUTH reaches for the bag. HELEN holds it.

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN lets RUTH take one handle. She keeps the other. Neither pulls.

KIT: Are you going to expect me to do this for you?

HELEN: Of course not.

RUTH: I didn't expect it either.

RUTH releases her handle. She stays facing HELEN. HELEN puts the bag under her own chair.

KIT: Then why is she still here?

RUTH: Ask her.

HELEN: I asked you to stay.

RUTH: Yes.

HELEN: I've never said I didn't.

RUTH: You say it as though I came to dinner and wouldn't put my coat on.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: I had a coat on. I was going somewhere.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: The others waited for me.

HELEN: I know that too.

KIT: What others?

RUTH: We were going round together. Calling dances. A different place every --

HELEN: You hadn't said yes to them either.

RUTH: I had my coat on.

HELEN: You were standing in the passage.

RUTH: And you asked me to sit down.

A pause.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I wasn't the one who wanted all this.

RUTH looks around the room. HELEN follows her look as far as the chair.

KIT: You don't have to keep it because you wanted it once.

RUTH: Who's talking to you?

KIT: Everyone. When they want me to carry something.

RUTH: You keep picking things up.

HELEN: Can you both stop?

They stop. HELEN sits. She looks towards the chair again.

RUTH: You wanted me to talk.

HELEN: I remember.

RUTH: I'd done the shopping.

HELEN: I remember that as well.

RUTH: Two kinds of potatoes. You wanted to know why.

HELEN: I was trying to keep you talking.

RUTH: I know that now. I gave you quite a long answer.

HELEN laughs very slightly. It does not quite become a laugh.

KIT: How long was she meant to stay?

HELEN: There wasn't a --

RUTH: As long as I liked.

HELEN is still looking at the chair.

RUTH: That was what you said. Not until Thursday. Not until you'd found something else to do. As long as I liked.

HELEN's attention slips from RUTH to the chair. KIT follows the shift, as they followed her attention to the shoe. They receive something silently: a moment as HELEN remembers it, not an account of the whole night. KIT looks at HELEN, then at the bag and the entrance. They choose to speak.

KIT: She was on the floor.

HELEN looks at KIT.

RUTH: What?

KIT: When she said it. She was on the floor. She asked you to breathe louder.

A silence.

RUTH: Who told you that?

KIT: Mum just --

HELEN: I didn't.

KIT: You were --

HELEN: I didn't say it.

KIT: No. But you were there again. Just then.

RUTH looks at HELEN. HELEN does not look back.

KIT: She was frightened. She isn't now. You can go.

HELEN: You don't know what I asked her after that.

KIT: You can't keep making her be frightened so that you --

HELEN: Stop.

HELEN turns to KIT. She holds out her palm. KIT starts to take it. HELEN closes her hand and places it on the table.

KIT draws back, abruptly alone in their own posture.

KIT: Oh.

HELEN waits.

KIT: The water's gone.

KIT: I wasn't trying to look at that.

HELEN: But you said it.

KIT: It was there. With the water.

HELEN: I know where it was.

KIT: You let me --

HELEN: To see something I'd made. I wanted to show you.

KIT looks at her, tries to begin again.

KIT: Mum.

HELEN waits. KIT has to make the request aloud.

KIT: Can I come back?

HELEN: No.

HELEN gets up and goes through the entrance. KIT stays where they are.

KIT: Mum?

No answer.

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN *(from beyond the entrance):* What?

RUTH: I didn't mean to --

HELEN *(from beyond the entrance):* I'm coming.

HELEN returns. KIT has no shared view of her experience. RUTH has reached her in the same way she did before the trial.

Silence. No one finds a job.

RUTH: I thought you'd gone to sleep.

HELEN: Not then.

RUTH: No. I know. You kept waking --

She stops.

A little time.

KIT: We're late.

HELEN: Go, then.

KIT: Neri's expecting you.

HELEN: I said I'd try.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: What did you tell them?

KIT: I thought we'd be finished.

HELEN: What did you tell them?

KIT: Yes.

HELEN nods once.

KIT: You said you'd try. You always say that. I thought if I said you were coming, you'd --

HELEN: I'd what?

KIT: Come.

RUTH sits down. The displaced chair is awkwardly far from the table. She stays where it is.

KIT: I wanted you there.

HELEN: You could have asked me.

KIT: I did ask you. You said you were listening and then she called and you said one minute. So I waited. I was still there when you came back. You didn't remember I was still there.

HELEN cannot immediately answer.

KIT: I know I shouldn't have said it. The thing just now. I know. But I'm not making that bit up.

HELEN: No.

KIT: Will you come?

HELEN: I can't promise you that now.

KIT: They're waiting for us.

HELEN: They don't know they're waiting for us.

KIT: They know I'm here.

HELEN: You have to tell Neri what you said.

KIT: I could tell them we're nearly --

HELEN looks at KIT.

KIT: All right.

KIT goes to the entrance. They look back at HELEN, then at the bag.

KIT: I'll come back.

RUTH: We heard you.

KIT leaves.

HELEN and RUTH sit apart. The bag is under HELEN's chair.

Neither speaks.

What this passage has and has not tested

On the page, a proposed solution becomes an experiment; Ruth agrees to leave; Helen obstructs her; Kit exploits information received through permitted intimacy; Helen withdraws that intimacy. Those are drafted actions, not evidence of audience comprehension or a successful performance.

The performance questions are specific:

- Can three actors make the shared experience readable without added sound, mime illustrating unseen scenery, or explanatory speeches?
- Does the retained trace of water make it clear that Kit's invited contact continues after Helen adopts the familiar manner?
- After the water disappears for Kit, is Ruth's continuing ability to call Helen clearly a different relationship?
- Does the interval of successful quiet make Ruth's choice of Sal's company feel like a decision, rather than a hurt exit?
- Does the private detail feel unmistakably acquired in this encounter, and does Kit's use of it hurt before anyone needs an account of the mechanism?
- Does Ruth's readiness change the room's energy enough for Helen taking the bag to be shocking?
- Does Helen's longer account sound like this particular woman enjoying her work, or like a writer providing attractive world-building?
- Does the last exchange expose Kit's real injury without cancelling what they have done?
- After the disclosure, do listeners still want the mother and daughter to resolve the move, or has Kit's offence taken over the play?

The mother's dance story and Helen's account of the tide may need different lengths aloud. The remaining movements are outlined, not yet scripted.